Domingue (which restored its Taíno name, Haiti, after the slave rebellion that freed it from France) retreated entirely from global markets, and soon Spain's mainland colonies followed the United States and Haiti in fighting for and eventually achieving independence. In the nineteenth century Spain turned its full attention to its much-reduced Caribbean empire, with Cuba as its centerpiece.

Over a million slaves were brought to the island in less than a century. African slaves continued to pour into Cuba until 1866, and slavery itself was not abolished until 1886. Between 1790 and 1867, 780,000 arrived.[4] A substantial proportion of today's population of Cuba is at least partly descended from these Africans: estimates range from 30 percent to 60 percent.

Others arrived in Cuba also. As British pressure to end the slave trade increased, Cuban planters turned to China, and in the middle of the nineteenth century some 100,000 Chinese were imported to work in conditions not far removed from slavery. Large numbers of Spaniards continued to arrive both before and after Cuba gained its independence in 1898. U.S. investors, including both individual planters and well-known companies like Hershey and the United Fruit Company, began to take over the production of sugar in the late nineteenth century. In the early years of the twentieth century, the United States orchestrated a large influx of migrant workers from U.S.-occupied Haiti to labor on the plantations. Sugar workers also migrated from Jamaica. Refugees came from Europe, including Jews fleeing the Nazis and Spanish Republicans fleeing the 1936–39 Civil War and subsequent Franco dictatorship.

In an influential body of work in the 1940s, Cuban anthropologist Fernando Ortiz argued that Cuba's population was characterized by the phenomenon of *transculturation*. Each successive group of migrants, he explains was "torn from his native moorings, faced with the problem of disadjustment and readjustment, of deculturation and acculturation." Cuba's history, "more than that of any other country of America, is an intense, complex, unbroken process of transculturation of human groups, all in a state of transition."[5]

The United States may seem to share Cuba's multiracial, transculturated character, and in many ways it does. There are, though,